WHY BIHAR STANDS OUT

This is not the first time that the poll panel has ordered a statewide "intensive" revision of electoral rolls. At least nine such revisions were held from 1952 to 2004, several of which came with similar house-to-house verification and even a "de novo" (from scratch) electoral roll in some cases. What makes the Bihar exercise unique is its hybrid nature and compressed timeline. Besides, the ECI has seldom ordered a full intensive revision in a state 4-6 months ahead of an assembly election. "Updating electoral rolls is essential," former CEC S.Y. Quraishi says, "but doing so just four months before election in a flood-prone, high-migration state like Bihar is a recipe for trouble. The issue isn't legality. It's about practicality, desirability and the political optics surrounding the move."

Bihar's last intensive revision took place in 2002-03, as part of a larger nationwide effort that unfolded in phases across 20 states. While the enumeration phase from July 15 to August 14, 2002, also lasted 31 days, the revision was completed a full three years before Bihar's assembly election in October 2005, allowing ample time for corrections, appeals and public familiarisation with the new roll.

In addition, the 2002-03 revision was done from scratch, compared to the current exercise, which discriminates between voters based on when they were enrolled, creating different documentary requirements for different cohorts. Those who appeared on the 2003 electoral rolls, roughly 49.6 million people, need only to submit an enumeration form with an extract from that old list, which has been made available online. But the remaining 29.3 million face steeper requirements. Voters above 40, who are missing from the 2003 electoral list, will have to provide documentary proof of their citizenship, identity and residence. Those born between July 1, 1987, and December 2, 2004, have to provide proof of their own date and place of birth plus similar documentation for one parent. Those born after December 2004 need proof for themselves as well as both their parents.

The ECI has specified 11 acceptable documents (see *Documents that Count*), excluding Aadhaar cards, PAN cards and driving licences, because, as officials explained, none of these prove citizenship. Critics point out that five of these 11 documents do not display the applicant's place or date of birth, both mandatory for inclusion in the updated voter list. Two of the documents that meet the criteria—the National Register of Citizens (NRC) and the family register—are not maintained in Bihar.

PROOF AND PREJUDICE

Currently, to register as a voter, an individual needs to fill out Form 6, which does not require proof of citizenship. Instead, applicants are asked to submit self-attested documents to establish age and address. Acceptable age proof includes birth certificate issued by a competent authority, Aadhaar card, PAN card, driving licence, Class X or XII mark sheets from recognised boards, or passport or any other document with proof of date of birth. For address proof, applicants can submit documents in their own name or that of a parent, spouse or adult child (if already an enrolled voter at the same address). These include utility bills (minimum one-year-old), Aadhaar, bank or post office passbook, passport, land records, rent or sale deeds, among others.

Since none of these documents establish citizenship, BJP leaders have repeatedly argued that the process is vulnerable to misuse. "Isn't it true that sometimes Rohingyas or other such individuals illegally get their names added to the voter rolls? If the work is being done with full honesty, then what is the objection?" asked Ravi Shankar Prasad, former Union law minister and BJP MP from Patna.

Opposition parties have slammed the exercise as being politically motivated, accusing the BJP-led Union government of manipulation. On July 9, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, joined by INDIA bloc allies, led a protest march in Patna against the move. A significant fear they have is that the BJP's organisational strength and resources will enable it to better assist its supporters, often from upper-caste and urban demographics, in navigating the

DOCUMENTS THAT COUNT

Eleven official records that the ECI has specified as acceptable



1. Identity card/ pension payment order of a PSU employee or pensioner
2. ID/ certificate/ document issued by govt, local bodies, banks, post offices, LIC, PSU (pre-July 1, 1987)
3. Birth certificate issued by a competent authority
4. Passport
5. Matriculation/ educational certificate from a recognised board or university
6. Permanent residence certificate issued by competent state authority
7. Forest rights certificate
8. OBC/ SC/ ST or any valid caste certificate
9. National Register of Citizens (wherever it exists)
10. Family register
11. Land or house allotment certificate